

At the end of my elementary school period I was beginning to notice the antagonism against Jews. At one point it became known that I was planning to leave for England and that I was Jewish. I was followed home by a gang of kids my age, jeering at me, calling out I was a Jew. I remember that one non-Jewish friend in my class went with me and came up to my apartment, and his parents then came to take him home.

I also remember watching the massive parades and watching Hitler, and joining in the excitement. My parents didn't want to tell us too much, so I didn't know what was going on. I remember this iron discipline that was being imposed. There was some event when I was in high school. A line of older boys were standing at attention on the platform. One of them, still standing straight, just keeled over, because he couldn't step out. He couldn't say he wasn't feeling well.

Another frightening thing, which may have had something to do with the mood, was when some boys pushed one boy of their age into a wire trash basket and rolled him down a hill, jeering him. I don't believe that boy was Jewish.

Somewhere around this time, maybe it was after I left, laws had been promulgated that children of Jewish background had to go to separate schools beginning and ending at separate times, so that the public would recognize them as Jews. When the Aryan kids were at school, if you saw boys and girls still out on the street, you'd know they were of Jewish background.

Friends of ours, the Mendl family, had emigrated to England maybe two years earlier, to establish a London branch of a German firm that the father, Gerald Mendl, was associated with. They had a son my age, Wolfgang, who was going to Watford Grammar School. They suggested to my family that I should go to school there and go home during vacations. So I went in 1936, and my mother came with me to deposit me. The plan was that I would come home each vacation, which I did through the summer of 1938. I sailed on those transatlantic luxury liners, the Bremen and the Europa, which stopped at Southampton and then went on to either Bremen or Hamburg.

Again, it was idyllic. I was really going off to a lovely place and coming home on vacations. On one of the boats, Max Schmeling was coming home after being defeated by Joe Louis. I saw him at a distance in a lounge area, and there was great excitement.

My mother would hide things in my suitcase. She denied it later, but this definitely was told to me by the Mendls. She would hide jewelry, for instance, in my suitcases to smuggle it out of Germany, and sent notes to the Mendls to look for the items when we opened them.

BENFEY: Right. I was under-age for being drafted. The British got so scared of a fifth column, of the possibility that the Nazis had infiltrated Nazi agents in the wave of refugees, that many refugees of Jewish background were rounded up. Wolf Mendl's father, from then on, had a packed suitcase ready to go. Many of these people were shipped off to Australia, and at least one of my relatives ended up there. Wolf's father was an engineer designing oil refinery equipment. Before the war started, his branch of the German firm had become an independent company in England. When the war started, I think he worked for a British firm who kept on supplying him documents saying he was doing work of national importance.

But for Wolf's mother, it must have been frightening. She was quite frail, and she kept on taking on other waifs and strays like myself. At times there were at least three other people living there pretty permanently, and others who would come for briefer periods. For a while, she also had her sister helping, doing the cooking. That produced strains, but we all managed. During the bombing, we all slept downstairs, so we had this gang of six or seven boys and girls of all ages, sleeping in sleeping bags or the equivalent, all in the living room. That too was enjoyable rather than frightening, because again, we didn't know the details of what was happening. I was too young to visualize the panic or what might happen to us if the Nazis invaded.

The way I connected with University College was that I chose chemistry during the year in the sixth form at school. My father in Germany had been able to give some of his money to a Jewish fund that could still ship money out, whereas by the time he left he could take nothing. Right at the end, whatever the Nazis found you still had in the bank, they demanded from you as a leaving charge. There was an organization in London, Woburn House, which dispensed money for people like me who were separated from their parents, and maybe because my father had put this money into these funds in Germany, I received money from them. That money kept on coming regularly, this "Wundergeld," this wonder money, that helped with my expenses.

There must also have been funds made available for universities to offer places for students. One day I got a message saying that University College had a place for me and would I like to go? And so I went.

I should mention that we did have a chemistry teacher in Watford Grammar School who was not a very exciting teacher. He was rather stiff and formal as I remember him, but good and solid. He certainly didn't turn me off from chemistry, and helped me, presumably, writing letters of recommendation. We called him Inky Knight [R. W. Knight]. Wolf still lives in